

SIPRA DAS



Unfolding Terror Links

CHANDIGARH Call it a blast from the past or a sinister leak timed with the ongoing feud in the Punjab Congress. Even as state Congress chief and leader of the Opposition Rajinder Kaur Bhattal is locked in a factional war with her long-time foe and former chief minister Amarinder Singh, she has been rattled from an unexpected quarter.

A biography by Sandeep Kaur, widow of slain terrorist Dharam

Singh Kashtiwali of Babbar Khalsa, has created a ripple by darkly hinting that Bhattal had sheltered the outfit's militants at her home in Sangrur in 1991 and struck a deal with them for the release of her nephew Harpartap Singh, who was being held hostage. What has added to Bhattal's discomfiture is a statement by Sohan Singh, brother of a slain Babbar Khalsa militant, that she had secured his

PAST TENSE: Bhattal release from prison for a month to have her kin released unharmed.

Even as Bhattal rubbished the allegation, it came as god-sent for Amarinder who has asked her to come clean on her dubious past by facing a high-level probe. Worried over the political fallout of the controversy, the Congress high command summoned both feuding leaders to Delhi and sternly told them to clam up. But it has given a handle to the ruling SAD to beat the Congress with.

"The revelation reinforces the fact that the Congress mothered, nursed and promoted terrorism in Punjab for petty political gains and to defame the Akalis and the Sikhs," alleges SAD President Sukhbir Singh Badal, taunting Congress President Sonia Gandhi to break her silence on "terror connections of her Punjab chieftans".

Seems Amarinder is not the only adversary Bhattal has to contend with. **by Ramesh Vinayak**

Accent Barrier

MUMBAI Just when we thought our corporators would start conversing in English, the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) has been forced to abort its ambitious plan of classes in spoken English for its corporators. Unable to understand the "British accent" on the CDs and irked by the use of phrases like "Oh! What a pity" and "Oh dear! I am



The BMC building sorry", the corporators walked out of the class, demanding lessons in Hinglish. "An Indian accent and a colloquial way of speaking will be more useful and easier to understand," says BJP corporator Ashish Shelar.

The idea to impart language training and make corporators brush up their ABCs was proposed by BMC to facilitate better communication with visitors, especially foreign delegates. While classes have now been suspended, not all were opposed to it. "It is a welcome idea, especially, when we are talking about e-governance and establishing sister-city ties with cities in Japan and the US," says Shelar. For the time being at least, English is not a corporate idea. **by Aditi Pal**

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